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AUGUSTINE OF HIPPO
HERMENEUTICAL METHOD

SUBMITTED TO
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Short Biography

Augustine was born in Tagaste in 354 for a Non-Christian father Patricius and a devout Christian mother Monnica. After his schooling in Tagaste, he was sent to Carthage to be a student of Rhetoric. During his stay (373-382) there, he was drawn to Manichaeism. In Carthage, he had a son named Adeodatus through who a woman to whom he was not married to. In 384 he moved to Rome and then moved to Milan where he met Bishop Ambrose and eventually gave up on Manichaeism¹. Augustine and his son Adeodatus was baptized in 387 in the presence of his mother Monnica. After his mother's death Augustine moved back to Thagaste. In 391, Augustine began to assist Bishop Valerius of Hippo and after five years, he was appointed as Bishop of Hippo. He died in the year 430².

Philosophical Influence

“Augustine was a Platonist before he was a baptized Christian, and he was an admirer of Cicero before he was a Platonist³.” Augustine's philosophical influence begins with Cicero. As part of his study Augustine was required to read Cicero titled Hortensius, at the age of 19⁴. And to Cicero he would return after Manichaeism⁵. Augustine's quest for origin of evil lead him to Manichaeism and he would remain as one for the next nine years⁶. Mani (216-276) explained evil through pre-cosmic struggle between light and darkness⁷. And after being baptized, Augustine turned to Plotinus. Augustine's Philosophy got its doctrine from scripture and interpreted that doctrine in the light of Plotinus⁸.

¹ Gareth B. Matthews, *Augustine* (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2005), 11.

² John M. Rist, *Augustine: Ancient Thought Baptized* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 2-4.

³ (Rist 1996, 23)

⁴ Henry Chadwick, *Augustine of Hippo: a Life*, Reprint ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, USA, 2010), 10.

⁵ (Rist 1996, 2)

⁶ Gareth B. Matthews, *Augustine* (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2005), 9.

⁷ (Chadwick 2010, 13)

⁸ Eleonore Stump and Norman Kretzmann, eds., *The Cambridge Companion to Augustine* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2001), 18.

Works

Augustine's work are voluminous, from among possibly 8000 sermons there survives 546 of them⁹. Augustine wrote his first book at 22 titled *On the Beautiful and the fitting*; the copy was lost¹⁰ that was the only work of Augustine before his conversion.

Soon after his conversion Augustine wrote his *De Genesi Contra Manichaeos* (388-390) to counter Manichaean teachings on Genesis. Before writing his *Confessions* (397), he wrote number of commentaries on scriptures. Some of his commentaries are *De Genesi ad litteram imperfectus liber* (Commentary on Genesis), *Epistolae ad Romanos in choata exposition* (an Exposition of Romans), *Epistolae ad Galatas exposito* (verse-by-verse commentary on Galatians) and *De sermone Domini in monte* (a commentary on the Sermon on the Mount).

Some of his short works are in form of collection of replies to question in *Quaestiones evangeliorum*. In which we find questions of Matthew, Luke and Ad notationes in Job. Some of his longer works *De Genesi ad litteram libri duodecim*, *In Joannis evangelium tractatus*, a collection of sermons from Gospel of John, *Enarrationes in Psalmos* and a commentary of first seven books of bible titled *Locutiones in heptateuchum*.

Exegetical Method

Augustine uses both Allegory and Literal methods in his writings. His writing on the book of Psalms titled (*Enarrationes in Psalmos*) is highly allegorical. He also uses allegory in his book *Confessions* especially in from Book 13 onwards¹¹. In contrast, his commentary on Galatians (*Epistolae ad Galatas expositio*) was on literal sense. His collections of sermons from the Gospel of John (*In Joannis evangelium tractatus*) “are a masterly blend of literal

⁹ (Rist 1996, 4)

¹⁰ (Matthews 2005, 10)

¹¹ (Stump 2001, 59)

and allegorical exegesis, philosophical speculation, moral exhortation, and theological polemic¹².” (CCA 60)

Augustine’s practice of exegesis cannot be generalized; his aim in exegesis is to bring about a full measure of Christian faith. His exegeses are not quick definitions but act as a call for the reader to look at things in a different perspective. Though he is sometimes prolix in some cases he is also concise. His writings are scholarly at the same time they contain exhortation and praise to God.

Augustine uses philosophical arguments in his commentaries. For example when Augustine talks about creation he relies on purely rational argument to show creation ex nihilo. And moreover he also uses another technique which is “he uses one part of scripture to illuminate another¹³”.

Exegetical Theory

Epistemological dimension of Augustine exegesis is that, an exegete can draw from both scripture and philosophy. He differentiates from allegorical and literal sense not by modern sense but by pointing out that the creation story is read as story of creation and not as the story of the church. What is learnt from scripture is learnt from the spirit of truth and from the Truth himself. And this truth is not past but present. Augustine generously open to variety of readings, he says that there is no one single true reading.

There is a Romantic inclination in Augustine’s exegetical theory. If the reader understands the words of the author which act like signs then “readers mind will exactly match the contents of the author’s mind¹⁴.” Therefore Augustine’s Romanticism is not to

¹² (Stump 2001, 60)

¹³ (Stump 2001, 61)

¹⁴ (Stump 2001, 64)

understand the author more than the author himself. But, Augustine believes that the Truth will lead the reader to the truth which the author has received from the Truth. In this, Augustine also understands the dimension of distancing in the text that the author is no longer available. But Augustine's method of retrieval is that scripture's author had the same source of Truth which is available even today, hence distancing is not a so much a loss.

Augustine accepts text's ability to produce multiplicity of meanings. And moreover Augustine believes that all truths in Scripture may not have crossed the mind of the author, hence Scripture needs Inner Teacher that is Christ "to show ... true meaning¹⁵" which can avoid errors. This Autonomy of Text (scripture) according to Augustine shows us that "there are also truths that belong to time and change, and our only independent access to those truths is through our senses."¹⁶ Scripture both directs our reason to see and reveals God's truth to us which neither reason nor sense can do.

Signs and Semiotics

Augustine's philosophy of language is "written words are signs of spoken words, and spoken words in turn are signs of the speaker's thoughts."¹⁷ Given the philosophical background Augustine draws on the idea of Signs from 'Platonic'¹⁸ and from 'Stoic's'.¹⁹

Darrel Jackson summarizes Augustine's theory of Signs as presented in *De doctrina christiana*. Signs are primarily Anthropological and secondly linguistic. Signs are classified as

1. "Things" or "Objects"

¹⁵ (Stump 2001, 65)

¹⁶ (Stump 2001, 66)

¹⁷ (Stump 2001, 64)

¹⁸ Phillip Cary, *Outward Signs: the Powerlessness of External Things in Augustine's Thought* (New York: Oxford University Press, USA, 2008), 3.

¹⁹ "Medieval Semiotics", <http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/semiotics-medieval/#2.1> (accessed on 26/Jan/2013).

2. Apprehension: By the way of understanding things through our senses.
3. Conception: Attention to what is known, more like “word image”
4. Signifying: Sign-giver deciding on what sign to give for the concept.
5. Communication: and finally meaning is acquired by the receiver through sign-giver who decides what sign to use for a particular concept by the means of sign.

Signs are inadequate to express the fullness and even when the signs are given readers have inadequacy to understand that which is to be understood of the sign. Augustine insists that “what comes out of the mouth of the speaker is not the reality signified, but only the sign by which signification is willed and attempted²⁰.” In Augustine’s theory of signs it is not the sign which is important but that which is signified is most important and we need the “inner teacher” to illuminate it.

Philip Cary in his work *Outward Signs on Augustinian Semiotics* puts forward a thesis calling it ‘Expressionist Semiotics.’ He argues that Augustine as a Platonist incorporates semiotics which was primarily used by empiricist. There is something new in Augustine’s expressionist semiotics, he “incorporates ... Platonist metaphysics of body and soul, thereby inventing the new category of bodily signs that are communicative expressions of the soul²¹.” Expressionist semiotics has a semiotic triangle that is words, things and thoughts.

Scripture as *Sign*

Scriptures acts like a pointer, the words of the scripture are signs which signify Truth. Words in the scripture “help direct our mind’s eye to the realities they signify²².” This pointing of the scriptures in their written signs does not make much intelligible meaning but they help reader in seeing the truth.

²⁰ (Rist 1996, 40)

²¹ (Cary 2008, ix)

²² (Stump 2001, 65)

Augustinian Method for Biblical Interpreters

For a Biblical interpreter Augustine tries to provide guidelines in his work *De doctrina christiana*. An interpreter must be careful in treating the signs. Signs are not end in themselves, but, an interpreter should take every caution to understand and explain the nature of things and sensibilities to which the signs point. In order to understand scripture the interpreter must have to skill to handle both unknown signs and ambiguous signs.

In order to understand the unknown signs and resolve any conflict, Augustine suggests that any Biblical interpreter must have thorough knowledge of Hebrew and Greek. And Augustine also suggests that an interpreter must have wide knowledge in the background of the world which the scripture represents. An interpreter should have

- Knowledge of plants, animals, and other things the scripture uses
- Should have knowledge in figurative understanding of numbers
- Should have fair knowledge of secular history
- Should be familiar with music, arts, trades, professions and sports not as professionals but to be able to understand when scripture talks about them

Moreover, an exegete can draw insights from secular (pagan) wisdom and philosophy, if it aides in more effective and intelligent reading of the scriptures. Augustine's openness towards secular philosophy comes from his own experience and exposure to Platonism and other philosophies of his time.

While providing methods for interpretation Augustine also provides moral guidelines for exegetes. He warns against the "lust of the eyes" and "pride of life" in exegetical practice. That is, an exegete should not pursue knowledge or seek to gain more knowledge just for the sake of gaining knowledge that Augustine calls as lust of the eyes. In the same way, when an exegete has an undue love for his exposition or interpretation that becomes pride of life. And

finally Augustine warns an exegete against another sin that is, “the desire for reputation as a brilliant scholar²³.”

An exegete should maintain consistency and his exposition should be always in line with the ‘rule of faith.’ For Augustine, every interpretation of the scripture should be charitable and its end should always be God²⁴.

Augustine’s Exposition: An Example

The following example of Augustine’s exposition is from his collection of homilies from the Gospel of John titled

*“On this passage of John: “In the beginning was the word, and the word was with God, and the word was God,” and so forth, until “and the darkness understood Him not””*²⁵

Augustine before expounding the passage, begins with a note that each one receives what he can and even the one who speaks only what he can (referring to himself). And he goes on to say that even John himself was able to say what he could. Whilst talking about evangelist John he uses allegory from Ps 72:3 *“The mountains shall bring peace to the people, and the little hills, by righteousness”* Figuring John as mountain and believers as hills. John as mountain received peace for the people.

In order to receive the revelation, John ascended to the heart of wisdom. John received wisdom of God so he may bring peace to the people. This revelation brought in peace to people unlike some mountains and rocks which shipwreck people’s faith (referring to heresies). Moreover Augustine, admonishes his listeners not to fall into the error of looking

²³ (Stump 2001, 66)

²⁴ (Stump 2001, 66-70)

²⁵ Saint Augustine and Mary T. Clark, *Selected Writings (classics of Western Spirituality Series)* (London: SPCK Publishing, 1985), 267.

up to those mountains which bring peace and place their hope in those mountains (people who bring in revelation of God). Again using allegorical interpretation of Ps 121:1-2 “I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help. My help cometh from the Lord, which made heaven and earth.” Even though revelations come from mountains hope remains only with God.

Augustine then speaks about the Word that was in the beginning and he goes on to examine the meaning of the word and also the meaninglessness of the word because of its everyday use. He contrasts between the Word of God and our word which he says “In speaking daily our words have lost this value for us”, when referring to this value he refers to the creative value of the Word. Furthermore he analyses in his sermon the use of the word ‘GOD’ and what it signifies. “I utter a word when I say: God. A very short word, three letters and one syllable...what happened in your heart when you heard the word God? What happened in my heart when I said the word God? A certain great and highest substance is thought of”²⁶

Word of God is the basis of all creation. And this word does not have a beginning but was God himself. Therefore all creatures are of God’s creation even “flies.” In order to explain the idea of Word, Augustine uses the anecdote of chest-maker, where wooden chest made from the idea of its maker.

Critical Review

Augustine’s homily uses allegory and scriptural reference to expound. As man of his times Augustine’s homilies were used to safeguard his listeners against heresies. But, there is something profound in Augustine’s thinking, his openness towards revelation of God’s word

²⁶ (Augustine 1985, 272)

and limitation of human understanding in receiving and dispensing it. However, he does not look at it from as a serious limitation but as something as unique trait of each individual.

Secondly his views on “words” reflect his understanding as something which can guarantee signifier. This view is seriously criticized by post-modern thinkers as “transcendental-signified.” But, Augustine as a serious thinker had stirrings of a critical thinking about signs and signifiers even during his time. His question “what happened in your heart when you heard the word God?” is definitely as post-modern question.

Exposition using Augustine’s Exegetical Method

The following is an exegetical attempt by using Augustine’s exegetical method. Scripture portion taken is John 2:11

“Jesus did this, the first of his signs, in Cana of Galilee, and revealed his glory; and his disciples believed in him.”

Jesus did his first sign (σημείων) in Cana and his disciples believed. God performed his signs (mopheth) Exodus 7:3 *“But I will harden Pharaoh’s heart, and I will multiply my signs and wonders in the land of Egypt”*. Signs in Egypt hardened the hearts of people. Therefore Signs performed in Egypt and Signs performed in Cana, which is part of the Promised Land Canaan are different. Egypt is when our hearts are not saved whereas Canaan is where our heart is saved by the Grace of God, to understand his manifestation. It is God who hardens and opens our heart. Through Moses we received “law” but through Jesus Christ we received “Grace” (John1:17), the Law of Moses was a veil over our hearts (2Cor 3:15). This Sign points to a Glory, which signifies God himself. Water becomes Wine and signs become glory, God becomes Man and Man sees God.

In the above exposition I have used three principles of Augustine, Using Scripture to expound scripture, use of allegory and virtue of spiritual truth. In order to contrast between uses of signs an earlier reference to Sign which is used in the OT is used. Allegorical method is used where Egypt stands for unsaved and hardened heart and Canaan for saved and believing heart. Finally the truth is that water turning into wine could reflect a spiritual virtue of our hearts when believing the Son of God becomes like wine.

Final Remarks

In an attempt to broadly map out Augustine's exegetical method, few things stand out starkly. They are his theory of Semiotics, his openness for multiple readings of scripture and his emphasis on virtue of spiritual truth. Augustine stands out as an exceptional thinker, who had stirrings of critical thinking what we now call postmodern thinking. As man of his times Augustine seemed to have been influenced by Platonism and other philosophies. He used his philosophical influence in theology to build a stronger apology for Christian faith and to counter heresies.

For today's context Augustine's method can be advocated for multiple readings of scripture to counter fundamentalism in scriptural exegesis. His virtue of spiritual truth that is learnt from the Inner Teacher can be much appreciated today.

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